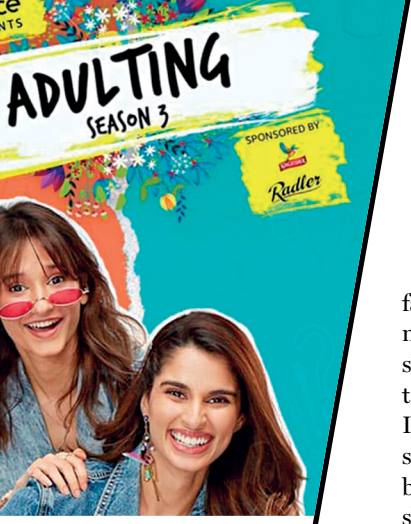




It was the style and success of Four More Shots Please! that drove other OTT players to develop shows on female friendships



fact that the female perspective was missing on screen—it was also that she had hardly seen "three women talking without mentioning a man". In 2015, Sharma wrote a short story—'Bitches of the 90s'—which became a bible for *Girls Hostel*, a show where bonds are forged not on the basis of the "men we have in our lives". Sharma says, "We are who we are in front of our girlfriends and that is never shown. Female gangs don't need anything else to hang out." As she and other writers set out to capture these aspects, the challenge was to make the everyday engaging. "Screenplays where the stakes are low and drama-free are harder to write," she adds.

While most of these shows are given a breezy treatment, they also address real issues. "I think all women are hilarious," says Sharma. "Our form of comedy is sarcasm. We come across as underdogs in any situation and we give a different perspective." The bingeworthy appeal of many of these shows is heightened by how relatable their characters are.

With *FMSP*, Patpatia felt that the series offered all that and was also "brave and bold", which invariably meant that everybody would have an opinion on how its women were portrayed. In season three, Patpatia says, the show will "go beyond romance" to focus more on the individual women. "When men look at any female-led show, they think it is all about boys and sex. I feel we have evolved from there. It's not the only thing that defines us." In *FMSP*, the best of adventures happen when the four come together at a scenic location—this season, the girls go to Italy. "You'll see their friendship evolve, a few fallouts and also patching up," she says. "That's the beauty of a girl gang. With women, it is very rare to just end your friendship. We forgive easily and have each other's backs, no matter what." ■

Suhani Singh

SOUL SISTERS

International shows that champion female bonds



BIG LITTLE LIES
(2017-2019)
Disney+ Hotstar

Starring Reese Witherspoon, Nicole Kidman, Shailene Woodley, Laura Dern and Zoe Kravitz, this show revolves around a group of five women in California, held together by a dark secret that pushes them to the edge.



VALERIA
(2020–)
Netflix

Having hit a block with both her writing and her husband, Valeria, the protagonist of this Spanish comedy drama, finds comfort in her three friends—Carmen, Lola and Nerea.



BAD SISTERS
(2022)
Apple TV

Your sisters can sometimes be your most trusted friends. Based on the Flemish show *Clan* and set in Ireland, this dark comedy sees four women plot to save their sibling from her abusive husband.